

Asian Americans as the Model Minority: An Analysis of the Popular Press Image in the 1960s and 1980s*

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The year 1986 marked an anniversary of sorts: twenty years earlier, the first articles proclaiming Asian Americans as the “model” minority appeared in the popular press. Since then, the model minority thesis has been the target of considerable criticism. Members of the Asian American community have argued that the image is racially stereotypic, empirically inaccurate, and no longer applicable to the changing Asian American population. Yet, in spite of these critiques, the image remains dominant in the 1980s, appearing in numerous popular press articles in recent years.

The analytic focus of this chapter is the persistence of the model minority image into the 1980s. It will examine how the image of Asian Americans as the successful minority has been able to withstand criticism and changing conditions, yet remain an important conceptual force in the popular press. It will compare the discursive construction of the model minority image as portrayed in the popular press during two historical periods – the 1960s and 1980s – and discuss how that discourse has been shaped by surrounding social and political conditions. The comparative analysis will reveal how changes in the discourse on Asian American success have enabled it to maintain relevance and explanatory power in the contemporary literature.

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Elements of an Image – 1960s

At the beginning of January 1966, William Petersen went to great lengths in a *New York Times Magazine* article to praise the efforts of Japanese Americans in their successful struggle to enter the mainstream of American life.¹ In December of that same year, the *U.S. News and World Report* also published a story lauding Chinese Americans for their remarkable achievements and praised Chinatowns as bastions of peace and prosperity.² As with the Japanese Americans, the article praised the Chinese for their ability to overcome years of racial discrimination.

The newfound “success” image for both groups rested upon a foundation of two basic elements. The first was the empirical evidence for success. Embedded in each story were a number of “facts” that substantiated Asian American success. Statistics on the educational achievements of Japanese and Chinese headed the list. Other evidence of success included movement into high status occupations, rising incomes, and low rates of mental illness and crime.

Second, the articles offered an explicit theoretical explanation for why Asian Americans had succeeded. At the heart of this explanation was a direct link between traditional Asian cultural values and subsequent achievement in education and occupations. Petersen argued that Japanese Americans’ adherence to values such as a deep respect for parents and authority, a reverence for learning, and a proclivity for hard work created a psychological achievement orientation that drove Japanese to do well in school. Similarly, the *U.S. News and World Report* article identified cultural emphases on hard work, thrift, and morality as factors that helped Chinese Americans to overcome obstacles and move up the socioeconomic ladder.

Asian American Success – Ideological and Political Implications

The 1966 articles marked a significant turning point in the public’s perception of Asian Americans. After enduring a century of blatant racial discrimination and negative stereotypes, the Japanese and Chinese suddenly found themselves cast into a favorable light. In place of the unassimilable, inscrutable Fu Manchu and the vicious *kamikaze* pilot emerged the image of the high achieving, successful minority.

This image of Asian American success did not appear in a vacuum. The definition of a new racial identity emerged at a moment of tremendous racial upheaval in America. The Civil Rights Movement, increased state intervention in race relations, urban riots, and black militancy collided in the mid-1960s, touching off intense debates on the direction of racial politics.³

In this context, the Asian American success story took on new meanings. The accomplishments of less than one-million Asian Americans emerged as a model

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for how all minority groups could “make it” in society. The articulation of successful Asians in the popular press carried ramifications that extended well beyond the Chinatowns and Japantowns of America.

On the political level, Asian American success constituted a direct critique of Blacks who sought relief through federally supported social programs. Asian Americans, we were told, were able to make it on their own. Welfare programs were unnecessary. “At a time when it is being proposed that hundreds of billions be spent to uplift Negroes and other minorities, the nation’s 300,000 Chinese-Americans are moving ahead on their own, with no help from anyone else,” declared the *U.S. News and World Report*,⁴ and wrote Petersen: “By any criterion we choose, the Japanese Americans are better than any other group in our society, including native-born whites. They have established this remarkable record, moreover, by their own almost totally unaided effort.”⁵

Asian American success also sent a distinct political message to the nascent Black Power Movement. The achievements of Asians diffused the black militants’ claim that America was fundamentally a racist society, structured to keep minorities in a subordinate position. The Asian American experience identified cultural values and hard work as the keys to success. The political implication for those who had yet to make it was that their culture was not “good” enough. This delineation of good and bad culture deflected attention away from societal factors and placed the blame for racial inequality on minorities.⁶

Beyond these political implications, the model minority thesis presented a picture of American society that resonated with dominant ideological precepts.⁷ Asian achievement confirmed that the United States was indeed the land of opportunity. It defined success in narrow, materialistic terms. The movement of Asians into the mainstream of American life affirmed the ideal that America was an open society, willing to accept and incorporate those minorities and immigrants who were willing to assimilate. Perhaps most importantly, the thesis upheld a fundamental meritocratic belief that America was a fair society.⁸ Asian Americans had made it because America judged and rewarded people, not by the color of their skin, but on the basis of their qualifications, skills, attitudes, and behavior.

The model minority thesis, then, was far from a neutral construct. It was an image that carried political and ideological implications specific to the historical conditions of race relations in the mid-1960s. I now turn to the 1980s, where the nexus of political, racial, demographic, and economic conditions demarcates a historical context in sharp contrast to the 1960s. The following sections will look at how the changing context of the 1980s has altered the discourse on the Asian American experience.

Incorporating Change and Dissent – 1980s

Between 1982 and 1986, ten articles on Asian American success appeared in major popular press publications.⁹ Two changes in the focus and content of the

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discussion on Asian American success in the present period are immediately apparent. First, the articles all recognized the changing nature of the Asian American population. The focus of these articles was on Korean, Vietnamese, and other foreign-born Asians, rather than on Japanese and Chinese Americans. This modification is directly attributable to the tremendous demographic changes that have occurred over the past twenty years. Since the 1965 Immigration Act, Asians have become the fastest growing minority in the country. From 1970 to 1980, the Asian population grew from 1.4 to 3.5 million people. During this period, the Korean population increased 400 percent from 69,000 to over 350,000, while the Filipino population more than doubled from 340,000 to 780,000, and the Chinese population grew from 435,000 to 812,000.¹⁰ In addition to these immigrants, the Asian American population has grown due to the influx of nearly a million Vietnamese and Southeast Asian refugees after the fall of Saigon in 1975.

Second, the articles displayed a greater recognition of the complexities and critiques associated with the model minority thesis. Three out of the ten articles presented substantial discussions on the negative impact that parental pressures have had on Asian American students.¹¹ Four articles acknowledged the stereotypical nature of the success image, and noted the resentment that some Asians feel toward being considered the model minority.¹² In a related theme, six articles pointed out that Asians were entering arenas not previously associated with the quiet Asian image, such as politics, business management, art, fashion, and music.¹³ Six articles mentioned that one of the indicators of success, median family income, was somewhat misleading because Asians tend to have more workers per family.¹⁴

That complex portrait of the Asian American experience reflects the recognition in the popular press that the Asian community has grown more diverse in the past fifteen years. In addition to the immigration that has brought highly skilled people into new occupational settings, the social movements of the late 1960s and 1970s, that included the Asian American Movement, heightened the political, social, and cultural consciousness of many Asian Americans. In this context, many Asians were encouraged to explore a broader range of political and cultural arenas.

The inclusion of potentially negative consequences in these articles also acknowledges a more comprehensive understanding of the model minority thesis that has been developed through scholarly research. The sensitivity to stereotyping and the pressures associated with success, for example, stems from the research on culture and identity that emerged in the early 1970s.¹⁵ The critique of certain statistical indicators of success flows directly from the critical research on the Asian labor market experience.¹⁶ These studies showed that median family income was not a good measure for success because it masked the fact that the per worker income rates for Asian Americans fell significantly below that of comparably educated whites.

Consistency Amidst Change

The incorporation of new information and dissent is one way the discourse on Asian Americans has changed in the 1980s. The increased comprehensiveness of contemporary articles may lead one to conclude that the popular press is taking a more critical, fair, and balanced view of Asian Americans, and that the articles are less political than similar stories in the 1960s. Further examination, however, reveals a certain consistency amidst change. The core elements of the original model minority thesis – the empirical evidence for success and a culturally based explanation for achievement – continue to be an integral part of the current discussion on Asian Americans.

The educational achievement of Asian Americans, for example, remained a critical indicator of success. In nine of the ten recent articles, the outstanding performance of Asian students in the Westinghouse Science Talent competition was cited as a measure of achievement. In seven of those articles, the high percentage of Asian students in universities was offered as proof of educational success. In seven stories, Asian student success was substantiated by their above average SAT scores in math.

In explaining this success in school, the articles offered a theory that is consistent with the 1960s model minority thesis. At the heart of the explanations are familiar, culturally based attributes. In all ten articles, the Asian American family was mentioned as a key to educational success. Anecdotal stories of refugee parents working sixteen hours a day to pay for their children's education; of mothers insisting that their children study long hours; and of parents impressing upon their children the importance of education were offered to illustrate the influence of the family. Hard work and a reverence for learning also returned in the 1980s as vital to success. References to hard work appeared in five of the ten articles;¹⁷ and the reverence for learning appeared in four stories.¹⁸ In four articles, the reasons for Asian success were encompassed under the broader influence of Confucian ethics, where education was sacred and scholarly achievements were a way to express filial piety.¹⁹

The continued reliance on culturally based explanations for success mirror the same dominant ideological assumptions that articles from the 1960s rested upon. Asian American success once again reaffirms that America is a land of opportunity, where people are rewarded for their hard work and diligence. The rapid movement of Asian immigrants into the educational and economic mainstream proves that America is still open, fair, and able to incorporate industrious people. The stress on educational achievement and subsequent occupational mobility remains the main, albeit narrow, criteria for success.

Political Implications of the 1980s Image

In addition to maintaining the core elements of the original model minority thesis and conveying dominant ideological messages, contemporary articles continue to address political concerns. What must be noted, however, are changes in the form and content of those political messages that reflect changes in the surrounding racial and political climate. Borrowing from authors Michael Omi and Howard Winant, these discursive changes represent a "rearticulation" of Asian American success images in the 1980s, in which core elements of the discourse are infused "with a new political meaning and link(ed) with other key elements of conservative political ideology."²⁰ This rearticulation is achieved in three ways.

First, the overt racial comparisons between the success of Asians and the failures of other minorities are tempered and replaced in the current literature by a non-racial discourse that focuses primarily on differences between Asian American families and "American" families. In several articles, the authors suggest that Asian American families are "better," which accounts for their remarkable success. In "Why Asians Succeed Here," the author quotes a professor who says that "Asian families pay more attention to their children,"²¹ and the *U.S. News and World Report* article cites the following observation: "If an American child isn't doing well in school, his parents think the teacher or school has failed or the student just doesn't have it. The Asian parents' view is that the student isn't trying hard enough."²² In "Why Asians are Going to the Head of the Class," the writer states that "Asian or Asian American parents are able to instill in their children a much greater motivation to work harder," and quotes conservative scholar Thomas Sowell's observation: "Asian parents are teaching a lesson that otherwise isn't being taught in America anymore. When you see a study that says Asian kids study harder than white and black kids and are getting better grades, it tells you something."²³

While many of these comparisons are made in non-racial terms, they carry significant racial meaning in the conservative political action and discourse of the 1980s. Praise for the Asian American family is a consistent part of a broader conservative perspective that blames many of today's social problems on the deterioration of the family. President Reagan's attacks on abortion and school busing, and his support for school prayer and tuition tax credits have been made in the name of restoring strength to the family and community. That many of these policies constitute direct attacks on programs originally designed to benefit racial minorities speaks to the subtle manner in which the elevation of family is actually a code word to disguise underlying racial concern.²⁴

Second, the discussion on Asian American achievement is shaped by conservative educational reform proposals that have emerged from the recent national-level debates on public schools. In the fervent debates following reports such as *A Nation at Risk*, many suggest that American education could be improved by lengthening the school year and increasing the amount of homework in school.²⁵

References to these conservative reforms infuse the dialogue on Asian Americans. Three articles argue that the longer school year in Asian countries, roughly 225 days compared to 180 in the United States, plays an important role in the educational success of Asian immigrants.²⁶ One of the articles attributes success to the work ethic of Asians and their willingness to do homework. It cites a study that found that American first grade students spent an average of fourteen minutes a night on homework and hated it, while Japanese first graders spent thirty-seven minutes and Chinese spent seventy-seven minutes on homework and loved it.²⁷

Finally, the discourse on Asian American success, particularly in higher education, is linked to growing anti-Asian sentiments. "A Drive to Excel," for example, explicitly mentions that the growing number of Asian students in universities are resented by white students, who feel threatened. It reports stories of white students dropping courses if there were "too many Oriental faces." It also tells of jokes that MIT stood for "Made in Taiwan," and UCLA was "University of Caucasians Living Among Asians."²⁸ The controversy over admissions ceilings for Asian students is another arena where Asian American success appears to be the basis for discriminatory action.

The notion that Asian American success constitutes a potential threat is also expressed in subtle forms. A *New York Times Magazine* story exemplifies this in describing Asian Americans as "*surging into the nation's best colleges like a tidal wave*"²⁹ (emphasis added), and another author, in referring to the increase of Asians at Harvard, writes: "The figure is now 10% – five times their share of the population."³⁰ In both instances, Asian success is discussed in almost alarming tones, reminiscent of the "hordes" of Asians that threatened California in the late 1800s.

The irony that Asian American success has become a basis for discriminatory backlash is understandable in the context of growing anti-Asian sentiment in the 1980s. The decline of the American economy in the 1970s and the concomitant competition from Japan has given rise to increased tensions between Asians and Whites in the 1980s. These tensions have manifested themselves in numerous instances of violence against Asian Americans as exemplified by the 1982 murder of Vincent Chin. [Chin was a 27-year-old Chinese American who was killed in Detroit by two white men who thought he was Japanese. Much attention has focused on the brutal beating of Chin by these two men, who used a baseball bat to beat him and made racially charged remarks to Chin on the evening of the beating. The men were all but acquitted of the crimes; widespread Asian American protests erupted around the event.] Discrimination and resentment in universities is another manifestation of those growing hostilities.

Tilting the Scale

Contemporary articles on Asian American success are remarkably pliable constructs. They have expanded to incorporate new information and critiques of the

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model minority thesis. At the same time, they maintain the core elements of the original model minority thesis, that continues to address political and ideological concerns. The question remains: what is the overriding message expressed in these articles? Does the incorporation of new information and critiques balance the image of Asian American success and create a fair picture of the Asian experience in the 1980s, or do the articles largely perpetuate a stereotypic view of Asians as the model minority?

I would argue that the portrayal of Asian Americans continues to be largely stereotypic. The dominant message conveyed is that Asian Americans are successful and have overcome discrimination with determination and hard work. This message is evident in the titles alone that grab the reader's attention and impart an initial image of Asian Americans as successful.

Beyond the titles, the image of Asian American success, and the explanatory emphasis on culture, family, and hard work, is constructed through a number of discursive mechanisms. First, the texts of articles invariably contain key sentences or passages that assign analytic *priority* to information that supports the model minority thesis. For example, the review of studies on the educational achievement of Asian Americans in the *New York Times Magazine* concludes with the sentence: "It is here [the family] that almost all the studies converge."³¹ This simple sentence plays the critical role of identifying and prioritizing the family as the key to success, even though studies might suggest a range of explanations. Similarly, the essayist in the *New Republic* observes: "Social scientists wonder just how this success was possible.... There is no single answer, but all the various explanations of the Asian-Americans' success do tend to fall into one category: self-sufficiency."³² These two passages provide an interpretive framework for the reader.

Second, the model minority thesis is upheld by passages that *minimize* the impact of contradictory information. This is most evident in the discussion on median Asian American family income. As mentioned earlier, six articles cite high median family incomes of Asian Americans as an indicator of success.³³ Five of the articles acknowledge that this measure is problematic because Asian American families tend to have more income earners than the norm, or because there are large numbers of Asian Americans in poverty. The inclusion of this information, however, does not alter the dominant message that Asian Americans are economically successful. In four of the five articles, the authors minimize or discount the importance of the critiques.³⁴ One article discusses the critiques, then says, "Yet success stories abound. Even among recent Indo-Chinese refugees, large numbers have climbed out of poverty and found jobs."³⁵ Another article prefaces the critique of family income with the following line: "By at least one indicator, it seems hard to believe that Asian-Americans suffer greatly from discrimination."³⁶ These minimizing passages are important for they enable authors to include potentially contradictory information yet still maintain the overall model minority thrust.

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Finally, the articles promote the model minority thesis through the selective use of scholarly research. Research studies that support the notion that families are the key to Asian American success appear as authoritative evidence. For example, three articles cite Harold Stevenson's study of education in the United States, Japan, and Taiwan to substantiate their claim that Asian families instill a proclivity for hard work.³⁷ On the other hand, research that is critical of the model minority thesis never appears in the articles. This is particularly true in the discussion on median family income. There are no references to the extensive body of research that shows that Asians earn less than their educational levels would normally warrant.

Conclusion

I conclude this discussion with a simple but important image. Todd Gitlin, in describing how hegemonic ideologies operate, writes, they "stand still, in a sense, by moving."³⁸ This analysis of the treatment of Asian Americans by the popular press illustrates how this process works. There was significant movement in the discourse on Asian Americans in the 1980s. The articles have been updated through the incorporation of new information. They have withstood critiques, not by denying them, but by acknowledging them and then minimizing their power through a variety of discursive techniques. They have maintained relevance in the 1980s by changing to address contemporary political issues.

Notes

- 1 William Petersen, "Success Story, Japanese-American Style," *New York Times Magazine*, January 9, 1966, 20-1, 33, 36, 38, 40-1, 43.
- 2 "Success Story of One Minority in the U.S.," *U.S. News and World Report*, December 26, 1966, 73-8.
- 3 Stokely Carmichael and Charles V. Hamilton, *Black Power: The Politics of Liberation in America* (New York: Vintage Books, 1967); and Frances Fox Piven and Richard Cloward, *Poor People's Movements* (New York: Vintage Books, 1977).
- 4 "Success Story," 73.
- 5 Petersen, "Success Story," 21.
- 6 William Ryan, *Blaming the Victim*, rev. edn (New York: Vintage Books, 1976).
- 7 Ira Katznelson and M. Kesselman, *The Politics of Power*, 2nd edn (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1979).
- 8 Samuel Bowles and Herbert Gintis, *Schooling in Capitalist America: Educational Reform and the Contradictions of Economic Life* (New York: Basic Books, 1976).
- 9 The ten articles reviewed in this section, chronologically ordered, are: "Asian Americans: A 'Model Minority,'" *Newsweek*, December 6, 1982, 39, 41-2, 51; "Confucian Work Ethic," *Time*, March 28, 1983, 52; "A Drive to Excel," *Newsweek-On Campus*, April 1984, 4-8, 12-13; "A Formula for Success," *Newsweek*, April 23, 1984, 77-8; Suzana McBee, "Asian Americans, Are They Making the Grade?," *U.S. News and World Report*, April 1984, 41-3, 46-7;

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- "To America with Skills," *Time*, July 8, 1985, 42–4; David Bell, "The Triumph of Asian Americans," *New Republic*, July 1985, 24–31; Fox Butterfield, "Why Asians are Going to the Head of the Class," *New York Times Magazine*, August 3, 1986, 19–24; Robert Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here," *New York Times Magazine*, November 30, 1986, 74–5, 89–90, 92; and Anthony Ramirez, "America's Super Minority," *Fortune Magazine*, November 24, 1986, 148–9, 152, 156, 160.
- 10 Robert Gardner, Bryant Robey, and Peter C. Smith, "Asian Americans: Growth, Change, and Diversity," *Population Bulletin* 40 (1985): 2–44.
 - 11 See "Confucian Work Ethic"; "A Drive to Excel"; and "A Formula for Success."
 - 12 See "A Drive to Excel"; "A Formula for Success"; McBee, "Are They Making the Grade?"; and Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here."
 - 13 See "Asian Americans, a 'Model Minority'"; "A Drive to Excel"; "A Formula for Success"; McBee, "Are They Making the Grade?"; Bell, "The Triumph of Asian Americans"; and Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here."
 - 14 See "Asian Americans, A 'Model Minority'"; "A Formula for Success"; McBee, "Are They Making the Grade?"; "To America with Skills"; Bell, "The Triumph of Asian Americans"; and Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here."
 - 15 Ben Tong, "The Ghetto of the Mind," *Amerasia Journal* 1 (1971): 1–31; and Colin Watanabe, "Self-expression and the Asian American Experience," *Personnel and Guidance Journal* 51 (1973): 390–6.
 - 16 Amado Cabezas, "The Asian American Today as an Economic Success Model" (Paper presented at Break the Silence: A Conference on Anti-Asian Violence, Berkeley, 1986); Kwang Chung Kim and W.M. Hurh, "Korean Americans and the 'Success' Image – A Critique," *Amerasia Journal* 10 (1983): 3–21; and Morrison Wong, "The Cost of Being Chinese, Japanese, and Filipino," *Pacific Sociological Review* 25 (1982): 59–78.
 - 17 See "Asian Americans, A 'Model Minority'"; "A Drive to Excel"; McBee, "Are They Making the Grade"; Butterfield, "Going to the Head of the Class"; and Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here."
 - 18 See "Asian Americans, A 'Model Minority'"; "A Drive to Excel"; "A Formula for Success"; and Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here."
 - 19 See "Confucian Work Ethic"; McBee, "Are They Making the Grade"; Butterfield, "Going to the Head of the Class"; and Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here."
 - 20 Michael Omi and Howard Winant, *Racial Formation in the United States: From the 1960s to the 1980s* (New York: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1986), 114.
 - 21 Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here," 89.
 - 22 McBee, "Are They Making the Grade?," 42.
 - 23 Butterfield, "Going to the Head of the Class," 20, 21.
 - 24 Omi and Winant, *Racial Formation*, 84.
 - 25 National Commission on Excellence in Education, *A Nation at Risk* (Washington, DC: Government Printing Office, 1983).
 - 26 See "Confucian Work Ethic"; "A Formula for Success"; and Butterfield, "Going to the Head of the Class," 21.
 - 27 Butterfield, "Going to the Head of the Class," 21.
 - 28 "A Drive to Excel," 8.
 - 29 Butterfield, "Going to the Head of the Class," 21.
 - 30 Bell, "The Triumph of Asian Americans," 26.
 - 31 Butterfield, "Going to the Head of the Class," 24.
 - 32 Bell, "The Triumph of Asian Americans," 26.
 - 33 See "Asian Americans, A 'Model Minority'"; "A Drive to Excel"; "A Formula for Success"; McBee, "Are They Making the Grade?"; "To America with Skills"; and Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here."

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- 34 See "A Formula for Success"; McBee, "Are They Making the Grade?"; "To America with Skills"; and Oxnam, "Why Asians Succeed Here."
- 35 McBee, "Are They Making the Grade?," 42.
- 36 Bell, "The Triumph of Asian Americans," 28.
- 37 See "A Drive to Excel"; McBee, "Are They Making the Grade?"; and Butterfield, "Going to the Head of the Class."
- 38 Todd Gitlin, "Television's Screens: Hegemony in Transition," in *Cultural and Economic Reproduction in Education*, Michael Apple, ed. (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1982), 210.